GUEST COLUMN
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FIVE WAYS B-SCHOOLS MUST REINVENT

AS NEW TECH PUTS TRADITIONAL MBA CAREERS AT RISK, BUSINESS SCHOOLS MUST DIVERSIFY ADMISSIONS AND PRIORITISE CRITICAL THINKING SKILLS

ONE OF MY FAVOURITE GERMAN WORDS IS *SCHADENFREUDE*, A WORD THAT SOUNDS so much more impressive than its English equivalents, which would include "what goes around comes around". The best of our students are sent out into the world as bankers, consultants and corporate executives, and from their well-protected and well-paid perches, they have talked about disruption, often in positive terms, and when confronted with the disrupted (the brick and mortar retailers upended by the internet, the factory workers and miners displaced by cheap overseas labour), they have lectured them on the need to take one for the team and the benefits of globalisation and how they should "learn to code".

As AI has upended investing and business, it is quite clear that even if you do not believe that the trillions invested in data centres will pay off, it is changing business economics and threatening jobs. The difference, though, is that it is targeting the best-paid among us. As Indian business schools map their futures, here is some general advice on ways forward.

Firstly, stop expanding. Business schools are moving from being good businesses, with pricing power and high demand, to being bad businesses.

Secondly, reduce the cost of an MBA. Charge less tuition and shorten the degree from two years to one.

Thirdly, stop chasing number-crunchers. It's easier teaching a hundred history majors the number skills to value companies than getting a hundred engineers to trust their imaginations.

Fourthly, less content, more thinking power. Most business classes teach students how to work through models and mechanics. Few are oriented towards critical thinking skills.

Fifthly, stop (or at least slow down) the recruiting madness. It is overwhelming business schools, driving students to pick classes based upon who they want to recruit for, rather than what they should be learning.

Illustration by **RAJ VERMA**



DON'T COMPLAIN ABOUT DISRUPTION RUINING YOUR LIFE. A FACTORY WORKER MAY TELL YOU TO 'LEARN HOW TO PLUMB'. IT'S A NEW WORLD

Finally, if you are considering an MBA programme, reconsider the finances. If you are already in an MBA programme, while you cannot get your money back, be less picky when eyeing employers. ■

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